MOREH NEVUCHIM

Approaching the Divine: Moshe, the Burning Bush & Gender in Torah

Given Tuesday 9 June 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim §1 · Ch 5–6

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** 1 · Chapter 5 (completed) & Chapter 6 (begun) **Topic:** Caution When Approaching the Divine · The Burning Bush Reinterpreted · Ish & Isha — Gender in Torah **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Recap of the Journey So Far

Chapter	Content
Introductions	How to learn the book, meshalim, the seven contradictions
1	*Tzelem* & *Demut* — the image of God = the intellectual faculty
2	Adam's sin — from objective truth (emet/sheker) to subjective good/bad (tov/ra)
3	*Temunah* vs. *Tavnit* — temunah with the divine = intellectual essence
4	The three verbs of seeing (ra'ah, habit, chazah) — sight vs. insight; with God, always insight
5 (begun last week)	The introduction: like Aristotle, approach metaphysics with caution — requiring (1) training in logic and science, (2) refined character

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PART 1 — Chapter 5: The Burning Bush Reinterpreted

The Scene (Shemot 3)

Moshe is shepherding Yitro's flock. He sees:

והנה הסנה בוער באש והסנה איננו אוכל — *The bush burning with fire — but the bush was not consumed*

Moshe says: *"Let me turn aside and see this great sight — why the bush is not burnt."* Then:

וירא ה' כי סר לראות — *Hashem saw that he turned to look*

Hashem calls "Moshe, Moshe," tells him to remove his shoes, and declares:

אנכי אלהי אביך, אלהי אברהם אלהי יצחק ואלהי יעקב

And then the critical verse:

And Moshe hid his face, for he was afraid to gaze at God **ויסתר משה פניו כי ירא מהביט אל האלהים**

(This continues directly from Chapter 4, where we learned the verb הביט.)

The Four Levels of Interpreting This Verse

Level 1 — The Crude/Heretical Reading ❌

Moshe physically sees God — a physical, corporeal God — and turns his face away in fear.

Absolutely rejected. As established throughout these chapters, God has no corporeality. This reading is heretical.

Level 2 — Saadia Gaon's Reading (Acceptable but Incorrect)

From **Emunot VeDe'ot (Essay 2, Chapter 12)**: Hashem created a special **light** (the *Kavod*, the *Shechinah*) which prophets see when Tanakh describes them "seeing God":

וכאשר יראהו אחד מהם אומר: ראיתי כבוד ה'

On this reading, Moshe saw a **physical light** — a created manifestation of God's presence — and was afraid to gaze at it.

Rambam's verdict (end of the chapter):

ואם ירצה אחד מהמתרשלים... להבין שראיית ה' היא ראיית אורות נבראים, מלאכים או אחרים — אין בזה נזק

"If one of those who do not reach the full level wishes to understand 'seeing God' as seeing created lights or angels — there is no harm in this."

Not harmful, not heretical — but not the correct interpretation. *(Rav Kapach identifies this passage as Rambam's implicit reference to Saadia Gaon.)*

Level 3 — The Correct Simple Reading (Rambam's Peshat)

The entire episode — the bush, the fire, the voice, the dialogue — occurred **in a prophetic vision, in Moshe's mind**. Moshe intellectually perceives the entire experience, hears Hashem declaring Himself, and is afraid. The "hiding of the face" is his reaction within the prophetic vision.

Level 4 — The Metaphorical Reading (The Point of This Chapter)

על ענין זה נאמר: ויסתר משה פניו כי ירא מהביט אל האלהים

"Moshe was afraid to gaze at God" = Moshe proceeded slowly, gradually, cautiously when entering the divine realm.

This isn't about the bush at all — it's about Moshe's entire approach to metaphysics, theology, Ma'aseh Merkavah. At the start of his prophetic journey (age 80, with trepidation — very different from the Moshe of Bamidbar who challenges Hashem in dialogue), **Moshe deliberately held back. He treaded with caution.**

Fascinating: Rambam is drawing a loose comparison between Aristotle (who opened his metaphysics with a plea for caution) and Moshe (whose hiding of the face WAS that caution).

Moshe's Reward for Caution

והשם יתעלה שיבחו על הדבר הזה... והאצילה מנעמו וטובו מה שהגיע לו בסוף — **ותמונת ה' יביט**

Hashem praised him for this — and as a reward, later in his career Moshe attained the clearest possible apprehension of God — *u'temunat Hashem yabit* (as explained in Chapter 3: the highest intellectual understanding available to any human).

The Gemara (Berachot 7a)

בשכר שלוש זכה לשלוש — *In the merit of three things, he merited three things:*

In the merit of...	He merited...
ויסתר משה פניו — hiding his face	**קלסתר פנים** — the radiant glow of his face
כי ירא — being afraid	**ויראו מגשת אליו** — the people's awe of him (Ki Tisa)
מהביט — restraining his gaze	**ותמונת ה' יביט** — gazing at the temunah of Hashem

Caution at the beginning purchased clarity at the end.

The Contrast — The Atzilei Bnei Yisrael (End of Mishpatim)

The Verses

וירא את אלהי ישראל, ותחת רגליו כמעשה לבנת הספיר וכעצם השמים לטוהר — *They saw the God of Israel — and under His feet was like a sapphire brickwork, like the essence of heaven in purity*

ואל אצילי בני ישראל לא שלח ידו, ויחזו את האלהים ויאכלו וישתו — *Against the nobles of Bnei Yisrael He did not send His hand — and they beheld God, and ate and drank*

(Linguistic note: אצילי from אצל — "to extend/set aside," as in Esav's cry הלא אצלת לי ברכה — "have you not reserved a blessing for me?" The Atzilim are those "extended" prominence — the nobles: the seventy elders plus Nadav and Avihu.)

Rambam's Reading

ואילו אצילי בני ישראל — **התפרצו ושילחו מחשבותיהם**, הם השיגו — אך השגה שאינה שלמה

The nobles were impetuous — they "burst forth" and let their thoughts loose. They DID attain a prophetic experience — but an incomplete, flawed one.

The Proof from the Verse Itself

לא נאמר "ויראו את אלהי ישראל" בלבד — אלא "ויראו... **ותחת רגליו**"

The Torah doesn't simply say "they saw the God of Israel." It adds **"and under His feet"** — crude, anthropomorphic content. Why?

כי מטרת הדברים אינה אלא **להטיל ביקורת על ראייתם**, לא לתאר כיצד ראו

The verse's purpose is to CRITICIZE their vision, not describe it. The anthropomorphic content ("His feet"!) signals that their apprehension contained **hagshamah** — some corporeality, some flawed conception of God.

(What exactly was the flaw? Rambam doesn't specify. Perhaps ascribing corporeality; others suggest they wrongly concluded there was pre-existent matter (hyle) alongside God — Plato's view, which Rambam rejects in Section 2. Either way: an error born of haste.)

The Consequence

כי מחויב בכך שהתפרצו לפני שהיו שלמים — **הם התחייבו כליה**

Because they burst in before they were complete — they deserved destruction. Moshe prayed for them and the punishment was deferred:

- The **seventy elders** — died in the fire at **Tav'erah** (Beha'alotecha)
- **Nadav and Avihu** — burnt in the **Ohel Moed** (Shemini)

Why Specifically Fire? — Two Interpretations

Rav Makbili's Interpretation

A contrast with Moshe: Moshe was cautious before the **fire** of the bush — they were not cautious — so they were destroyed **by fire**.

Rabbi Kada's Suggested Interpretation (the more beautiful one)

The nature of fire is impulsiveness.

Fire is one of the most important things in life — warmth, light, energy. But when does fire become dangerous? **When it moves too fast — when it spreads impulsively, without care for its surroundings.**

This is why Chazal compare **anger** to fire. Controlled displeasure has a function (as the Rambam and Rabbi Avraham teach in Ma'amar Al HaChassidut — a person shouldn't be a doormat); the destructive form is *fire-anger* — impetuous, consuming, careless.

The nobles ascended to Hashem **like fire** — too fast, impulsively, without gradual care. **Mida k'neged mida: they were consumed by the very quality of their ascent.** All of them — the seventy at Tav'erah, Nadav and Avihu at the Ohel Moed — died by fire.

The Midrash Confirms (Beha'alotecha)

The Midrash asks: Why does Moshe complain (in Beha'alotecha) that he has no one to help him? He already had seventy elders from Mishpatim!

Answer: Those elders had died —

שאף הם הקלו ראשם בעלותם להר סיני לשכינה — ונשרפו

They had acted with levity when ascending at Sinai toward the Shechinah — and were burnt. That's why Moshe needed seventy NEW elders.

Nadav and Avihu — The Same Mistake Twice

Why did Nadav and Avihu die earlier (Shemini)? **The same flaw**: they offered אש זרה אשר לא צוה — a fire that was not commanded. Whatever the precise sin (the interpretations are many), the common denominator: **impulsiveness, disrespecting boundaries, moving too fast in spiritual matters.**

Abrabanel's observation (noted by Rambam): they died **in the Ohel Moed** — the very place of divine inspiration. The location highlights the lesson: divine closeness is good; approaching it too fast, too casually, kills.

A Window into Elisha ben Avuya

With this framework, we can see how Rambam would read the Gemara of the **four who entered the Pardes**. Elisha ben Avuya became *Acher* — a catastrophic spiritual breakdown. Rambam would interpret: **he went too fast in the matters of the divine.**

The Kal VaChomer for Us

ואם כך היה לגביהם — **כל שכן לגבינו אנחנו הנחותים, ומי שלמטה מאתנו**

If this happened to the nobles of Israel — all the more so for us who are far lower (Rambam speaking of himself!), and those lower still (us, a thousandfold).

The Required Preparation

שראוי לו שיכוין עצמו ויתעסק **בהשלמת הלימודים המכינים**, ורכישת ההקדמות **המטהרות את ההשגה מטומאתה — שהיא הטעיות** — ואז ייגש להתבונן בכבוד הקודש האלוהי

1. **Complete the preparatory studies** (logic, science — as per last week)
2. **Acquire the prerequisites that purify apprehension from its impurity — which is ERRORS**
3. Only then approach contemplation of the divine

The Verse Reinterpreted — The Kohanim at Sinai

וגם הכהנים הנגשים אל ה' יתקדשו, פן יפרוץ בהם ה' *"The Kohanim who approach Hashem must sanctify themselves, lest Hashem burst forth against them"*

Simple reading: don't cross the physical boundary around Har Sinai. **Deeper reading:** The *Kohanim* — metaphorically, those who seek to experience the divine most intensely — must sanctify and prepare themselves. **Don't cross the boundary too fast, too casually, too impulsively.**

Shlomo's Warning

שמור רגליך כאשר תלך אל בית האלהים (Kohelet) *"Guard your feet when you go to the house of God"*

The Gemara reads this practically. The deeper meaning per Rambam: **guard your steps — tread slowly, cautiously, when approaching God.**

The Vilna Gaon's Parallel — The Ramp of the Mizbeach

ולא תעלה במעלות על מזבחי *"Do not ascend My altar by steps"* — a ramp was required instead.

The Gra explains: **steps are jumps — fast, discontinuous leaps. A ramp is slow, gradual, continuous ascent.** The altar's architecture itself teaches gradualism in approaching Hashem.

The Stunning Reframe — Impurity = Intellectual Error

Rambam said the prerequisites "purify apprehension from its impurity — **which is errors**." This is a profound redefinition: **tumah (impurity) = mistaken conceptions.**

The Source — End of Hilchot Mikvaot (Mishneh Torah)

דבר ברור וגלוי שהטומאות והטהרות **גזירות הכתוב הן**... ואף על פי כן **רמז יש בדבר**: כשם שהמכוון לבו לטהר — כיון שטבל טהור, ואף על פי שלא נתחדש בגופו דבר — כך המכוון לבו לטהר נפשו מטומאות הנפשות, **שהן מחשבות**

האון ודעות הרעות...

The laws of purity/impurity are decrees of Scripture — yet there is a hint in them. Just as one who focuses his heart to purify becomes pure upon immersion (though nothing changed in his body), so one who focuses his heart to purify his soul from the impurities of the soul — ***which are wicked thoughts and bad notions****...*

Impurity = wrong thoughts, bad conceptions, intellectual error. Mikvah without intention is just jumping in water; the purification is in the turning of the mind.

The Sharp Contemporary Application

The masses experience "God" most intensely at... **death.** Shiva customs, covering mirrors, candle timing — suddenly everyone is meticulous. The rest of the year — indifference. *(And unfortunately some rabbis cultivate exactly this.)*

That is precisely ascending to Hashem through tumah — through death, through error, through unprepared impulse — rather than through life, preparation, and clarity.

The Final Paragraph — "They Ate and Drank"

ואומר שגם מעשיהם התבלבלו בשל כך... ולכן נאמר: **ויחזו את האלהים ויאכלו וישתו**

Because of their intellectual error (born of haste), the nobles' **conduct** also became confused — they tilted toward corporeal things. Hence the verse stresses: *"they beheld God — and ate and drank."*

Not literal gluttony at the moment of vision — the point is that **their conception of God was materialized**, and so their engagement with the divine was entangled with the physical.

Mida K'neged Mida (As Always in Rambam)

There is no external "punishment" in Torah — punishment is the built-in consequence of the act. **They rushed the ascent → their apprehension came out corporeal → their experience of God was an eating-and-drinking one.**

The Contrast with Moshe — Perfect Symmetry

On the mountain forty days and forty nights:

Bread he did not eat, and water he did not drink **לחם לא אכל ומים לא שתה**

The Nobles	Moshe
Rushed in, unprepared	held back, cautious — ויסתר משה פניו
Vision contaminated with corporeality ("under His feet")	The purest apprehension (ותמונת ה' יביט)
"Saw God" while **eating and drinking**	**Neither ate nor drank**
Consumed by fire	Face radiant with light

Chapter 5 Summary

The verse *"Moshe hid his face, for he was afraid to gaze at God"* means — at the deepest level — that **Moshe entered the divine realm slowly, gradually, carefully.** The nobles, by contrast, had a vision — but a flawed, partially corporeal one, because they ascended without preparation. Their impulsiveness was repaid in kind: death by fire, the element of impulse. If that befell the nobles of Israel — all the more must we prepare: logic, science, refined character — purifying our apprehension from impurity, **which is intellectual error** — before approaching metaphysics and theology.

PART 2 — Chapter 6: Ish & Isha (Begun)

The Shortest Chapter — Five Lines

After five chapters on incorporeality, a digression. The whole chapter:

> **איש ואשה** — מונחים שנקבעו בתחילה לגבר ואשה. לאחר מכן הושאלו לכל זכר ונקבה משאר בעלי חיים... לאחר מכן הושאל המונח "אשה" **לכל דבר המוכן ומיועד להתחבר לדבר אחר**... הרי התבאר לך שגם אחות ואח הם רב-משמעיים על דרך ההשאלה כמו איש ואשה

1. **Ish/Isha** originally = human male and female
2. Borrowed for animal male/female: **מכל הבהמה הטהורה תקח לך שבעה שבעה איש ואשתו** (Noach) — "each man and his wife" = simply *male and female*
3. Then **isha** borrowed further: **for anything designated to join/attach to something else** — proof: **חמש היריעות תהיינה חוברות אשה אל אחותה** — the Mishkan curtains attached "each woman to her sister"
4. Conclusion: *ach* and *achot* (brother/sister) are likewise multi-meaning terms

Side Point — The Gemara in Sanhedrin

On "ish v'ishto" by Noach's animals, the Gemara asks: **אישות לבהמה מי אית לה?** (Do animals have marriage?) and answers: those that had not "sinned" (been promiscuous with other species). The Gemara reads "man and wife" as moral fidelity. **Rambam reads it far more simply: a borrowed term meaning male and female** — no marital union implied.

The Crucial Line — What This Chapter Is Really About

> **לכל דבר המוכן ומיועד להתחבר לדבר אחר** *"something else"* *for anything prepared and designated to join with..."*

(Per Rav Kapach — and it's clear — this is the key sentence. The Narboni reads the chapter as teaching that masculine language about God isn't literal; but Rambam never mentions God here, so that's unlikely to be the point.)

Ish & Isha = Tzura & Chomer (Form & Matter)

The creation narrative represents all existence. Everything in the universe reduces to the Aristotelian pair:

	Ish	Isha
Concept	**Tzura** — form	**Chomer** — matter
Mode	Potential, conceptual, theoretical, vision	Substance, receptacle, manifestation
Function	That which affects	That which is affected and actualizes

The Mishneh Torah Source (Yesodei HaTorah)

> *You will never see matter without form, or* **לעולם אין אתה רואה גולם בלא צורה, או צורה בלא גולם** *form without matter*

The chair analogy: the wood/legs = chomer; the conception "chair" = tzura. Form alone is a dream; matter alone is a lump. Only **together** do they constitute an existing thing.

Why Hebrew Is Gendered

Everything in Hebrew is masculine or feminine — because **everything in existence is binary: tzura and chomer, affecting and affected.** There is no non-binary in the structure of reality as Torah presents it.

(Rav Makbili suggests this underlies the Midrash that Kayin and Hevel were each born with twin sisters — creation as male-female pairing perpetuated into the second generation.)

The Verse in Bereishit Illuminated

In Bereishit Chapter 1: **זכר ונקבה ברא אותם** — created as *zachar* and *nekevah* (biological male/female).

Only after Chava is taken from Adam does the Torah switch terms:

> **לזאת יקרא אשה כי מאיש לוקחה זאת** *"This one shall be called ISHA, for from ISH she was taken"*

Isha is the receptacle/manifester of Ish — chomer actualizing tzura. The terminology itself encodes the form-matter relationship: the woman is designated to attach, to receive, to manifest in the world.

The Torah Implications (Rabbi Kada's Development)

1. On Egalitarianism

The expectation that men and women be **identical** — in roles, careers, expectations — is alien to Torah thought and against reality. **Different does not mean unequal** (that's a separate discussion) — but men and women are constitutionally different from the very structure of creation. The world is beginning to rediscover this.

2. On Marriage — Why It Completes a Person

If ish/isha = tzura/chomer, marriage is fully intelligible: **form without matter is nothing; matter without form is nothing. Only the combination exists.**

> **על כן יעזב איש את אביו ואת אמו ודבק באשתו והיו לבשר אחד** *Therefore a man leaves his father and" "mother and cleaves to his wife — and they become ONE FLESH*

One flesh = one complete existing entity. Hence:

"It is not good for the human to be alone" **לא טוב היות האדם לבדו, אעשה לו עזר כנגדו**

Without a spouse, neither can fully manifest. And the Gemara in Yevamot (the opening halacha of Even HaEzer): one without a spouse lacks many things — among them **shalom**. *Shalom* is from *shalem* — **completeness, full identity, manifested wholeness.**

3. On the Torah's Position on Homosexuality (A Deeper Layer)

Beyond the standard reasons (the act itself; no children — as most Rishonim write): a same-sex relationship pairs **tzura with tzura** or **chomer with chomer** — two forms or two substances — which cannot complete each other. The person believes they have a life partner, but in the deep structure, neither can actualize the other.

(Conjecture requiring further thought: perhaps this is why the Torah is more severe with male homosexuality — tzura-with-tzura may be a deeper incompletion than chomer-with-chomer.)

4. The Nuance — Both Within Each Person

Man is *primarily* tzura; woman is *primarily* chomer. **But every man has chomer within, and every woman has tzura within.** There are moments when a man is the affected and a woman the affecting. This matters for understanding human emotion — no one is a single essence.

Coming Up Next Week

- **Completing Chapter 6**: The beautiful **Kli Yakar** on how we relate to Hakadosh Baruch Hu — is God male? female? neither? both?
- **Chapter 7**: **Shedim** — demons. What do demons mean in Rambam's reading, and the meaning of "Adam fathered in his likeness and image"

Tonight's Summary

Chapter 5 — Caution When Approaching the Divine

- Four levels of "Moshe hid his face": (1) heretical-corporeal ❌, (2) Saadia's created light — acceptable, not correct, (3) prophetic vision in the mind — the peshat, (4) **metaphorical: Moshe entered the divine slowly and cautiously**
- His reward (Berachot 7a): the radiant face, the people's awe, ותמונת ה' יביט
- The nobles rushed in → flawed, partially corporeal vision ("under His feet"; "ate and drank") → destroyed **by fire — the element of impulsiveness** (mida k'neged mida)
- Kal vachomer for us: prepare with logic, science, character — purifying apprehension from impurity, **which Rambam redefines as intellectual error** (end of Hilchot Mikvaot)

the Mizbeach ramp (Gra) / the Kohanim at Sinai — all teach: **ascend gradually** / שמור רגליך

Chapter 6 — Ish & Isha (Begun)

- Ish/Isha → borrowed for animals → **isha = anything designated to attach to another**
- **Ish = Tzura (form); Isha = Chomer (matter)** — the binary structure of all existence

the terminology encodes form-and-matter — לזאת יקרא אשה כי מאיש לוקחה

- Implications: marriage as completion (לבשר אחד; shalom = shleimut); the Torah's view of gender difference; each person contains both

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B'Ezrat Hashem

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